A WINTON STORY

BY

NELLIE HOARE



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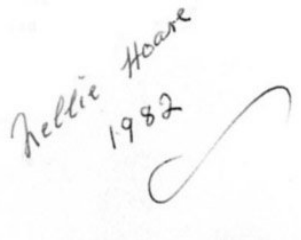
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NELLIE HOARE

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Mrs. Nellie Hoare in 1976

FOREWORD

In the Foreword to "My Story" by Pascoe Marshall, which was published in December 1981, we wrote - "The pity is that few men or women commit their memories to paper although there must be countless families where the cry is heard 'Why didn't Mum or Dad write down their story for the younger members of the family?".
Just as this book was published, Mrs. Nellie Hoare, having read some of the Group's booklets concerned with Local History, let us know that this was just exactly what she had done at the urgent request of her granddaughter, Wendy. She explained that Wendy was so determined the story should be written that she handed her grandmother a thick pad of writing paper and a new Biro. "Please, Grandmother", she said, "write down the stories you have been telling us all these years, so that all the family can read them".

So this is what Mrs. Hoare did and we were delighted when she agreed that this Group might publish her account. and we most happily agreed to prepare it for publication as a further booklet in our series. Mrs. Hoare has lived all her life in Winton, and since her birth in 1898 she has seen many changes and has faced, as the reader will find out, many challenges with great courage and determination. She has been able to draw on her exceptional memory to enable the reader to picture clearly the Winton of eighty or so years ago, as well as Winton in the less distant past. Her account is truly a document of social history and records a framework of life very different from that which operated in the more opulent homes of parts of Bournemouth. Not only are the constraints of life in a working-class home made clear, but equally we see how united the family were in support of each other and what happiness and joy came from simple activities and from rare but treasured treats. Hrs. Hoare's vivid turn of phrase recaptures life in Winton as it was when she was a child, a young woman, a wife and mother and then a widow, and it provides a series of pictures of this part of our town since the turn of the century.

Nora and Jack Parsons
Joint Presidents, Bournemouth Teachers‘ Centre
Local Studies Group.

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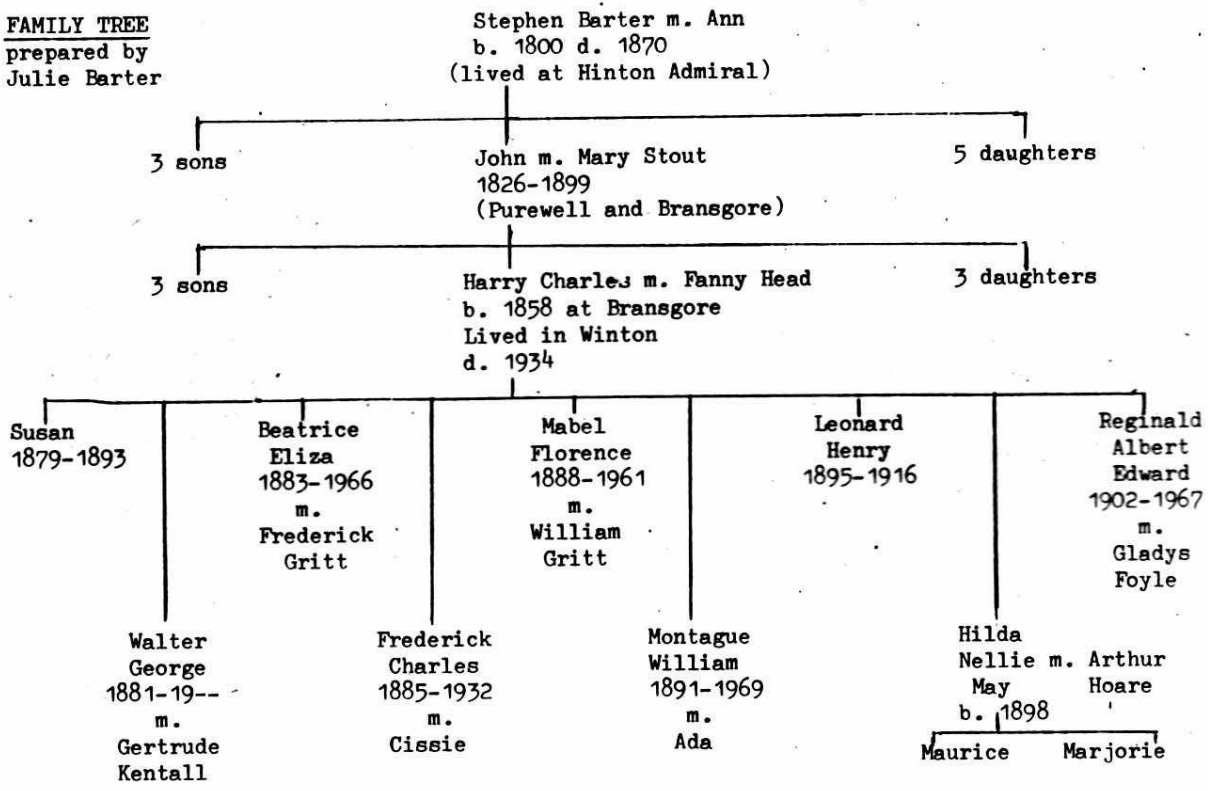
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Permission to reproduce the following photographs is gratefully acknowledged -

*Pages 29 and 30 - Evening Echo, Bournemouth, publishers of 'Bournemouth - A Pictorial Glimpse of Bygone Days'

**Page 30 - Mr. M. Ridley, Joint Author of 'Bournemouth Then and Now', published by Blandford Press.


FAMILY TREE
prepared by
Julie Barter
Stephen Barter m. Ann
b. 1800 d. 1870
(lived at Hinton Admiral)
3 sons
John m. Mary Stout
1826-1899
(Purewell and Bransgore)
5 daughters
3 sons
Harry Charles m. Fanny Head
b. 1858 at Bransgore
Lived in Winton
d. 1934
3 daughters
Susan
1879-1893
Walter
George
1881-19--
m.
Gertrude
Kentall
Beatrice
Eliza
1883-1966
m.
Frederick
Gritt
Frederick
Charles
1885-1932
m.
Cissie
Mabel
Florence
1888-1961
m.
William
Gritt
Montague
William
1891-1969
m.
Ada
Leonard
Henry
1895-1916
Hilda
Nellie
May
b. 1898
m. Arthur
Hoare
Maurice
Marjorie
Reginald
Albert
Edward
1902-1967
m.
Gladys
Foyle

Chapter One

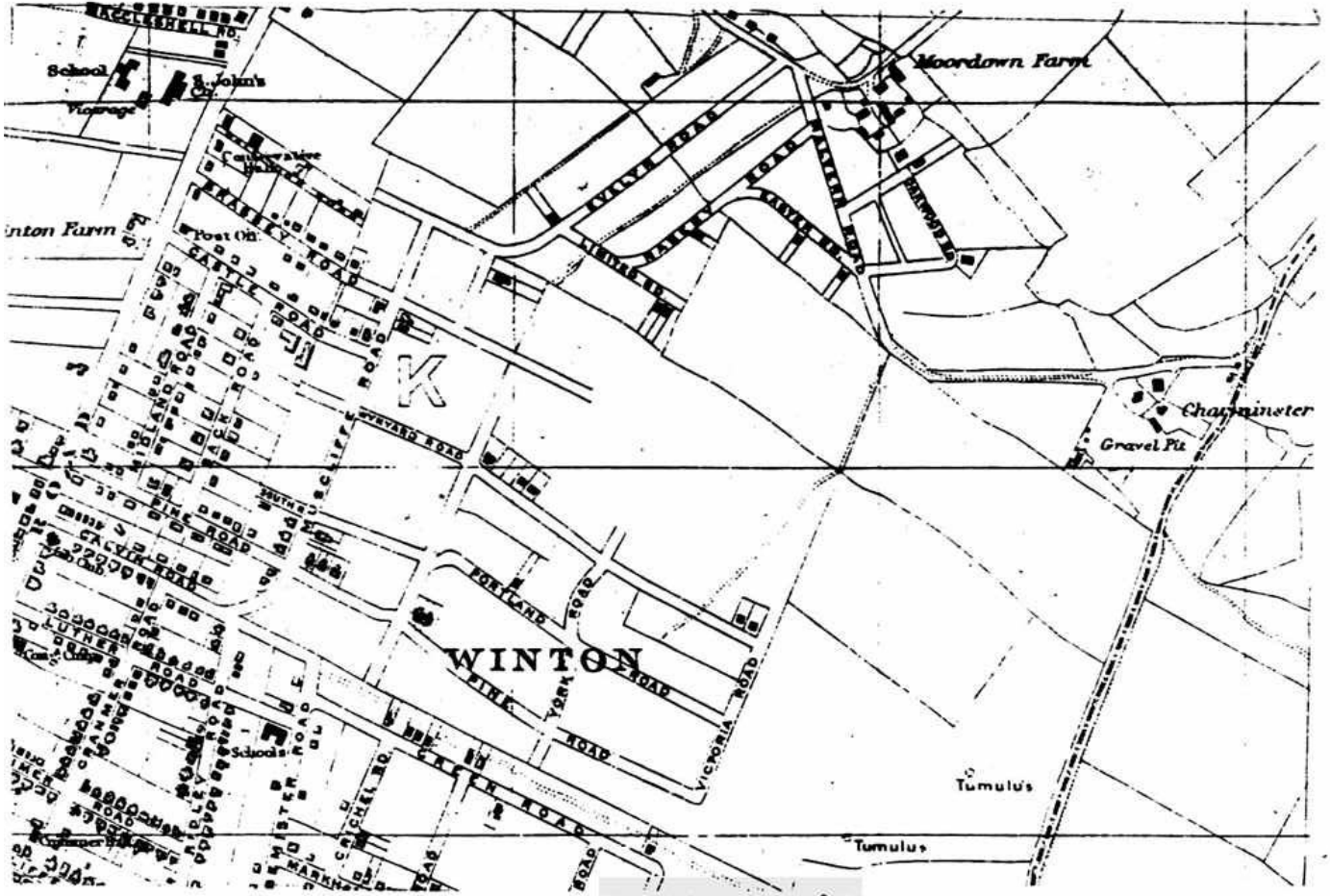
Home Memories

I began writing this story about my life in Winton as I thought that the younger ones of my family might be interested to read it and so discover what a change there is today from what it was when I was young. My memory is now not so good as it was and I may go backwards and forwards but perhaps that will not matter. I cannot remember anything about what happened until I was six or seven years old but, of course, I was told a good many stories about my family before I was born and I think that it might be interesting if I write something about what I was told about my parents and grand-parents.

My mother's parents were called Seymour and lived in a small cottage, known as "The Little Black House", in Malvern Road, about half a mile from where we lived in Midland Road. Mum would sometimes send me with a message, usually to see how they were getting on and I used to love going to see them. Granny would say "Hullo, me dear. Come in willya" (the old folk always talked like that), "Sit yourself down and tell me all the nuse" (she never said "news"). Then she would give me a glass of home-made lemonade, a piece of cake or some bread pudding. Sometimes the cake was very dry but I used to eat it up to please her but I do remember that one day she put a piece of cold suet pudding in front of me. I'm sure that it must have been about a fortnight old for it was cracking with old age but I did manage to get through it with a struggle. She was a dear old Granny and she lived until she was eighty-two, which was very old in those days. I remember that I was sixteen when she died.

I can only just remember my grandfather as he died when I was very young. when I got a bit older my mother told me how he died. He fell down the garden well and although one of the neighbours got him out and they rushed him to hospital he died within an hour. I remember he had grey hair and a grey beard.

My mother's name was Fanny Frances and my Dad's was Harry Charlie and they were married in about 1880. I think they were married at Holdenhurst Church and their first home was in Pine Road. They had nine children - four girls and five boys. The eldest was Susan Jane but she died when I was two years old so that I remember her only from a photograph. Next came Walter George, then Beatrice Eliza. She was followed by Frederick Charles and



Map of Winton in 1890

Mabel Florence. Then there were two more boys, Montague William and Leonard Henry John before I was born, to be called Nellie always although my full name was Hilda Nellie May. There were about two years between each of the first seven children but I was born four years after Leonard in May 1898. Finally Reginald Albert Edward was born four years after me.

My parents moved to Midland Road when I was about two years old and that must have been just, about the same time as the Bournemouth Daily Echo came out for the first time, which was in August 1900. My mother took it every day - a boy used to deliver it. They didn't charge for delivery then and the Echo cost only a half-penny. After Mother died, I always bought it, and even had it saved for me if I went away on holiday, so you could say the Echo and I grew up together.

I will tell you about my father next. He was a very nice father to us but I do not think that he was very fair with Mother. He was an outdoor worker - a labourer whose job it was to lay, kerb stones when new roads were being laid out and to lay pipes for drains, and sometimes he had to work with pick and shovel to repair the roads. The outdoor workers worked hard for their money in those days and most of his work - for instance, when he was working on the widening of the Square - was two to three miles walk every morning for he never rode on a tram unless it was pouring with rain and he was obliged to leave off work and come home. They could not work for long in the pouring rain and then, of course, would lose all the money for rainy days since they did not get paid for wet weather. In a fine week he earned about thirty shillings - but in a wet week nothing. When I was about fourteen years old Mother told me that he was not really fair to her. She said that he believed a man should share his wages with his wife, therefore if he earned thirty shillings Mother would get only fifteen shillings. He used to spend his fifteen shillings on beer and tobacco and I remember he smoked a clay pipe.

Later on in my story I will write about my older brothers and sisters but I am going to start now with some of my memories when I was quite young and will begin with the time when I was seven and my brother Reggie was three years old. On his third birthday he was 'britched'. That means that for the first time he wore trousers. In those days boys and girls all wore dresses, or frocks as they were called. The only difference in the dress of boys and girls was that little girls wore knickers but the little boys under three years wore nothing under the petticoat. I remember,

too, that on his birthday my mother stood him on the table to put his birthday present on him - it was a little sailor suit, with a sailor collar and a whistle. Well, I didn't think much of that as everyone was making such a fuss over him and I felt left out of things. I remember lying on the floor crying "I want a new sailor suit with a whistle". My Dad picked me up and said "Don't cry, you have a birthday coming soon so you will have your present then". Reg's birthday was May 8th and mine was May 21st. I thought it would never come, and what do you think I had when it did come? - a white pinny! I was very upset as I really thought that I would get a whistle.

In those days Mother could not afford to buy us presents. I was told this by my sister Beat when I got a bit older and could understand. All the brothers and sisters used to save a few coppers a week to buy the younger ones a little present for birthdays and for Christmas. When I look back on my life I remember that although we didn't get much in the way of presents or new clothes, we were happy with what we had. We made our own enjoyment - we used to skip a lot and play marbles and dibs. I remember that one of my brothers gave me a wooden hoop and stick for one of my birthdays and that I played for hours on end with that hoop, running up and down the road. Reg had an iron hoop with a wire hook with his and we used to have races up and down the roads. Of course, in those days there was not much traffic on the roads and only a horse and cart or a bike with solid tyres came along sometimes.

I can never remember being hungry in those days but we used to have very different food from that which people have today. We had no fancy cakes, jellies or ice-cream or sweets. Our food usually worked out like this. For breakfast we had bread and butter, or bread and jam, or bread and dripping and a cup of tea. Then we would go to school to be there from nine o'clock to twelve. We then came home for lunch when we would on some days have two slices of toast with half a hard-boiled egg. Hum could not afford one egg each so she used to hard boil the eggs, then cut them in half long-ways to make them look more, then we would either eat the egg first or put it between the bread and butter or the toast, and then we had a cup of tea or cocoa. On other days for lunch we would have a thick slice of bread dipped in bacon fat - if there was any fat left in the pan after my Dad or brothers had had bacon, although they didn't have bacon very often.

We always had a cooked dinner at about six o'clock when the men of the family got back from work. We always had

plenty of potatoes as my father had a nice vegetable garden and we had plenty of cabbage or beans or peas or whatever there was in the garden. We had enough meat but there was not much of a variety - we had either liver or cuttings. Cuttings were pieces of beef, lamb or pork that the butcher used to trim off the joints which the better-off people would not accept. We also sometimes had sausages. About twice a week we would have suet pudding boiled in a cloth with suet from the butcher, not packet suet - butcher's suet was much better. This reminds me that one evening when all the family was sitting down to dinner there was such a crash from the skullery. It was the cat who had been eating the pudding cloth which had been put back into the saucepan ready to be washed. The cat must have got on to the draining board and had a feed off the cloth as there was a big hole in its middle. The saucepan was a thick iron one and this is what he had knocked down. Imagine what a noise that made on the brick floor!

Bread pudding we had very often. I will never forget the bread puddings; they were cooked in a large meat tin in a kitchen range oven. When we used to get home we could smell the bread pudding and it didn't take us long to get washed and up to the table. Another thing I will always remember is that we children were allowed to talk for a little while after we sat at table but as soon as the older ones wished to talk we were told to be quiet and we knew we had to do as we were told or be sent to bed.

We kept rabbits when I was a girl and always had two or three for pets but there were others in another hutch for food. We used to fatten them up, then my brother Fred would kill one for Mum to make a rabbit stew.

My brother Reg, when he was young, used to wait for Dad to come home to see if he had anything in his lunch bag such as a piece of bread and cheese or meat. There was nearly always something left - I think that Dad left it on purpose as he knew Reg would have a look for some. Reg would sit on the doorstep and enjoy what he had found. I should think that it must have been rather dry after being in the lunch bag all day! The bag Dad took to work was made for him by Mum from an old coarse apron. Mother wore these when she was doing the washing and when one got too bad to wear as an apron the good parts were not wasted but were cut up for lunch bags. My brothers used them as well.

I remember that Sunday was the best day of the week for Reggie and me. We went out to play in the mornings while

Mum was busy cooking Sunday dinner. It was roast beef or leg of mutton usually but sometimes we had roast streaky pork and there were always roast potatoes, cabbage and swede or cabbage and peas. Always the peas were the packet dried peas that had to be boiled in a fine net bag. There was often also a skimmer cake which was boiled on top of the cabbage. It was really a sort of suet dumpling, only much larger, and it used to lie on top of the cabbage just as it was, with no cloth, and it had to be lifted out with a skimmer. This was a round iron thing about as big as a frying pan but with holes like a colander with a handle. We had the skimmer cake with our dinner and with gravy on it and we loved it. For afters we had rice pudding and for this Mum used to buy a quart of skimmed milk every Sunday and she used to cook the pudding in a quart-sized enamel pudding dish.

Of course we had no gas or electric stove and all our food was cooked on top of the kitchen range with a coal fire. There was a large oven on the side for the meat and puddings and when the dinner came out, in would go two home-made cakes One of these was extra large and was for the middle of the week; the smaller one we had for Sunday tea, still hot. These cakes were made with plain-flour and baking powder, dripping, sugar, Bird's egg-powder, and currants or raisins. Water was used to mix them as we could not afford milk for cakes but we used to love them. When Reggie and I used to come out of Sunday School in the afternoon (we only went once a day, in the afternoon) we used to run all the way home just to smell the cakes cooking. Sometimes the smaller one was on the kitchen table waiting for tea-time. How I used to love those Sundays!

I had very good parents and can never remember my mother or father hitting us but they had a way of talking and a way of looking at us which would let us know that we had to behave. We children had our Saturday jobs to do and mine was to hearthstone the brick copper and to scrub its wooden lid so that it was ready for Mother to start her washing on Monday mornings. She was washing all day on Mondays for there were no washing machines or spin driers. It all had to be done by hand and the table-cloths, aprons and pinnies, etc., had to be starched, then ironed with a flat-iron heated on the fire. It must have been very hard work for the mothers in those days.

Mum was always dressed in black or navy dresses or blouse and skirt. She and the other mothers never used to

wear coloured dresses or blouses and the skirts were down to their ankles. However, when Mum was doing her work she wore a white apron in the mornings with a bib and straps over the shoulders. In the afternoons she always wore a black satin apron to keep her dresses clean. Sometimes when she was going somewhere special she wore a dress with a white lace collar.

If we were not feeling well when we were children Mum used to give us a cup of hot milk and water, for we never had all milk as it was too expensive, so we thought it was great to have a cup of milk, even though we were not well, as it was the only time we did have it. If Dad had a cold Mum would give him a basin of boiled onions and if he had any money he would send one of us to the pub for four penn'orth of rum. We could get anything in the way of beer, stout or spirits in the Bottle and Jug department even if we were only in fourteen years old, but we had to take our own bottle or jug. If you did have to call in the doctor in those days you had to pay him for each call and the charge was about sixpence for each visit. Most people could not afford this so we had to doctor ourselves. When I was about twelve, a Doctor's Club was started and if you paid one penny a week and you really needed a doctor he would call, provided you had kept your payments regular, otherwise you had to pay him.

As there was no electricity or gas in the house I lived in as a child we had oil lamps and candles and, of there was no TV or radio. We had to make our own games and, while the better-off people had a piano to stand-around it and sing, we had nothing in the way of music, only a Jew's harp my Dad used to play and a tin whistle which one of my brothers had. He could get a few tunes on this such as "God Save the Queen". When it was too dark to play outside, Reg and I had to find our own amusement. I would look up any old books and play at "Spotting the Word". You play that by picking out one word from a page such as "they" or "do" and then going right through the whole page to find as many of the same words on that page as you could. I always started first as I was the elder and I drew a line underneath the word when I found it to see how many times I had got it. Then it would be Reg's turn on the next page and so on, and the one who found the most words won. We thought it great fun. Another game we used to play a lot was "Snakes and Ladders". We had an old board which I think must have been used for all the family as it was so old. We had a job to pick out which was the snake from the ladder

and if we lost a dice my Dad would make us one. He cut down a piece of wood to a square and put the dots on it and it worked perfectly all right. We also played "Tiddleywinks" and "Ludo" and when, for a change, we played out of doors we played dibs, skipping and diabolo.

We used to love Easter time as we knew we would have a Hot Cross bun. On Good Friday morning my Dad bought the buns that were his little treat for us every Good Friday and he used to wait at the gate with a dish for the man to come down the road with his basket of hot buns - and hot they were, tool Not like those we get now on the Thursday. The man would call out all down the road - "Hot Cross buns, Hot Cross buns, one a penny, two a penny, Hot Cross buns". Dad would come in with his dish of buns shouting "Hot Cross buns" and up to the table we would get and would have one for breakfast. Those were the days! As for Easter eggs, I don't think we had any - I can certainly never remember having one.

There were other men who came down the road. Some days we would get the Muffin Man in the road calling out "Muffins and Crumpets"; I can see him now with his basket covered with a white cloth. Sometimes we were lucky to get one toasted for tea when Mum had the coppers to spare - they were two for a penny ha'penny. There was also the Fishman who would come two or three times a week calling out "Fish!- Fish!- Fresh Fish!". You would see the mothers coming out to the gates with their dishes to buy herring, mackerel, kippers, sprats and bloaters. We used to love bloaters more than anything else.

Another man I remember coming along our road was always riding a penny-farthing bike. He lived in the next road and went to work on it so we often saw him. On Saturday nights we often saw the German Bandsmen who used to play outside the pubs. Some of the men used to come out of the pubs to give them a penny. The Salvation Army band also played outside the pubs and some of the Salvation Army girls used to go inside the pub to sell the "War Cry" and a paper called "The Young Soldier". They used to do very well as the men would buy a paper from them to take to their wives. Some of the men had had a good drop to drink and would ask the girls to have a drink but they always said "Not this time, thank you".

At Christmas time we had to go to church on Christmas morning and if Mother was very busy and could not come with us, we had to tell her all about the service when we came home. We did not get much in the way of presents - the

younger children would hang up a stocking but we did not get much in it and, for example, a girl might get a small wooden doll or a china-headed one with a stuffed body about four or five inches long, with no clothes on. We then had to dress it ourselves. If I was lucky I would get a picture book or a drawing book and a pencil in the stocking and at the bottom would be one orange, one apple and about three nuts and a few sweets. That was all. A boy might get a tin whistle or a top and a comic. There was a comic called "Chips" that Reggie used to like and he would also get the orange, apple, nuts and a few sweets the same as I got. We didn't have a Christmas tree but, to decorate the house, Reg and I made some paper chains from coloured paper strips and pasted these together with flour paste. Then we would hang these around the picture rail and across the room, and we also had some holly and mistletoe stuck around the room and we thought it all looked very pretty.

Some of the elderly people at the Day Centre I now go to were talking the other day about the Christmases we used to have and the games we played and the songs we sang. We don't do the same at Christmas any more which is a pity as we really did enjoy ourselves. We played Musical Chairs with a mouth-organ for the music, and Blindman's Buff and Pass the Parcel in which, when the music stopped, whoever had the parcel could keep it. Then there was the singing of carols around the fire and the old songs we sang together. If anyone could sing a song on their own or recite they were pleased to do so and we used to join in the chorus. We had roast chestnuts and potatoes in their jackets straight from the fire and it was great fun. We used to talk together whereas now we cannot find time to talk as we are too busy watching television.

Chapter Two

Schooldays

The school I went to was St. John's School at Moordown. It was built in February 1878 and I was very pleased to go to the school on the day that they celebrated the centenary. I still have some old photographs of the school and these were on show on the day. I was five years old when I started school and at first I went to the Infants' School which was held in the little St. John's Church building near the old Tram (later Bus) Depot in Wimborne Road, Moordown. It is now used as a timber yard for Willis, Builders' Merchants.

I and all the girls at school wore white pinnies with lace or frilling round the armholes and round the neck and hem when we got home we had to take our pinny off to keep it clean as we had to wear it two days at school unless it was very dirty. When we took it off we had to put on a coloured pinny to play in in order to keep our dress clean. We all had best clothes which we only wore on Sundays or if we went out with our parents. Schoolboys wore a sort of white rubber collar to school; these collars were kept clean by rubbing them with a soapy cloth which brought them up new again.

When I was about six I was going back to school after lunch when I saw Reggie playing opposite our house on a waste piece of ground. He often played there on the grass with the other little ones. This particular day he was playing alone and I asked him if he would like to go to school. He said he would so off we went. When I got to the classroom the teacher wanted to know who he was so I said that he was my little brother. She asked if my mother knew he was with me and, of course, I said she did. The teacher sat him next to me and he loved being there. Then my Mum came to the school to see if he was there as she had been running around everywhere she could think of, looking for him - I suppose she then began to wonder if I had taken him to school. When Mum saw Reggie she picked him up but he started to cry as he did not want to leave and she said to me - "I will see you about this when you get home".

I was not very happy the rest of the afternoon, wondering what was going to happen to me when I got home. Well, Mum was at the gate looking for me and all she said was "Get into the house!". I thought I was going to be murdered or something because Mum had a way of looking at you when you misbehaved. I ran into the house, she after me. She said



Nellie, aged four years



Nellie with brother Reggie
outside home



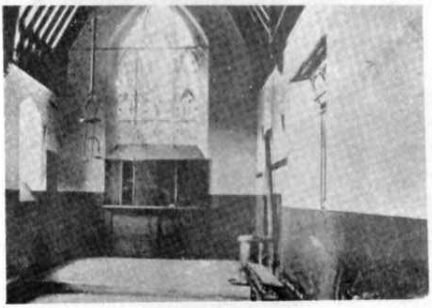
Barter Family Group in 1910



Children of St. John's School c. 1909



Exterior of St. John's in the Wilderness



Interior of St. John's in the Wilderness when used as a school

"Up to bed! No tea!" - so that was the end of my day. Mum didn't slap us for being naughty but, looking at her, we always thought she might!

When I was about seven or eight I went on to St. John's Girls' School in Vicarage Road. Every Thursday morning we would go to school as usual, say prayers and sing a hymn - usually "There is a green hill far away" or "All things bright and beautiful" - then the teacher would say "Put on your hats and coats, girls, we are going to march to church now". We used to love going to church. There we would listen to the Vicar and sing another hymn and have more prayers. After church we all marched back again to school and then it was nearly time for play. We all loved Thursdays as there was not so much work to do! - It is a pity they have stopped that as I am sure it was good for us. The children today do not hear many prayers and hymns as not many go to Sunday School now; we all went to Sunday School.

Our drills at school were much different from today. We had to put our hands on our hips, then stand on our toes and stretch our arms upwards, then sideways, then out in front. It was very difficult standing on your toes and some of the girls used to fall over, then most of us would start to laugh and giggle - until we got told off by the teacher!

I was a bit of a grizzler when I was young and if I was upset about anything I had my favourite corner in the living room where I would stand with my face to the wall, grizzling. No one used to take any notice but would walk into the room getting on with their work and that used to make me feel awful. I would not say a word, just keep on whining and I should think that it got on their nerves, but no one seemed to bother - I suppose they thought it best to leave me to come round in my own time. I can remember so plainly the time I must have spent in my little corner and especially one morning when my brother Fred was going off to work. It had been raining that morning so he did not leave for work until a bit later than usual but waited for the rain to stop. That morning I chose to be awkward and said I didn't want to go to school. Mum said "You'll go to school if I have to push you there in a pram!". Well, I didn't like that idea as I must have been about eight then, so off I started again in my little corner. In the end I had to go as Mum got the pram out, so off I ran to school. Well, when Fred came home in the evening I was there again in the corner and he thought that I had been there all day! For the first time he shouted at me as soon as he opened the door and saying "She's been

grizzling there all day!" he took off his cap and threw it at me. It frightened me that he was cross as he was always so gentle so I stopped crying and crept up to him and I remember he said "Are you going to be a good girl?" and I said "Yes". I crept up on his knee and I think that must have been the last time I cried in my corner.

I remember when I was about nine or ten all our school children had to walk to Meyrick Park. We marched most of the way from St. John's School to the Park, which would have been about two miles, I should think. When we got there we had a bun and a cup of lemonade and sat on the grass. After we had had a rest there was maypole dancing and all kinds of sports, including tug of war, a running race, an egg and spoon race and a sack race. I remember that I was one of those picked out for the Maypole dance. It was great fun as there was quite a crowd of people watching us. When it was over we were all very tired and we thought we had to walk all the way home again but then we had a surprise - there were two horse and waggon carts which came to pick us up.

We had no milk and dinners at school in those days, and if we were late for school we were sent to the Head Mistress and she would give us one stroke of the cane on the palm of our hand. You would be surprised how that used to sting. I remember one day for some reason I didn't want to go to school but in the end I thought I had better go, but I knew I would be late as I had been dawdling along the road for quite a while, and I did not fancy the cane. I found a small piece of pencil in my pinafore pocket but I had no paper to write on so I picked up an empty cigarette box and wrote on it - "Sorry Nellie is late for school this morning as she had to go to the shop. From Mrs. Barter". Of course the teacher knew my mother had not written it, so I had to own up - then I had two strokes of the cane, one on each hand!

I remember a girl at Day School; her name was Phyllis Burt and her father was a builder who used to do a lot of work at Winton. They lived either in Stanfield Road or Frederica Road, Winton. Phyllis was the tallest girl in the school and I was the next tallest so we became great friends, and I remember we used to call the other girls "Shorties". I often wonder if she is still alive - she would be my age now.

I can still recall some of the teachers' names; they were Miss Biles, who was Headmistress of the Infants' School, Miss Saunders who took the 'babies' class, Miss Evans who was the Headmistress of the Girls' School, Miss Rogers,

Miss Keevil and Miss Ivamy. Miss Rogers' father was a baker and had a baker's shop in Winton - on the corner of Pine Road, I think.

When I was a child there were only ten or twelve shops in our main road but now they stretch about two miles with shops on each side of the main road. We had one little shop we called "The Fancy Goods Shop" where they sold tape, elastic, cottons, buttons, hooks and eyes, press studs, pins and needles, fancy pencils, rubbers, lace hankies, children's hair ribbons, head bands, combs, hair pins and hair nets. The combs for ladies' hair that they sold were worn each side of the head to keep the hair in place. They also sold fancy belts and sashes, hat-pins and garters. Then there was Woolworth's and when they first opened all their goods were priced one penny, threepence or sixpence and there was nothing over sixpence. Yet another shop was called the "Penny Bazaar" and there nothing cost over a penny. Another shop sold materials for ladies' and children's dresses, blouses, skirts and night-dresses, for most mothers made their own and their children's clothes. The price of material for a child's dress was 2¾d. per yard for there was always a farthing on the end of the price of materials and sometimes the shopkeeper would say "Would you like the farthing change or some pins?". A lot of pins were used for pinning the materials together instead of tacking them.

The rest of the shops were bakers, grocers, a fish shop, a hat shop, fish and chip shop, a butcher's, fruit and vegetable shop and a cooked meat shop. There were also two pubs, a club, a shoe shop, an ironmonger's, a china and glass shop, a second-hand shop, and a small tea-shop where you could sit and have a cup of tea, cake or scones, or from where you could take away home-made cake. This same shop also sold a drink called "Vino", and lemonade and ginger beer. It was called "Anna Brown's" and was popular with the young lads and sometimes the girls also. They enjoyed going there and sitting in the shop in the evening after work for a cuppa and a chat; there were a few tables and a long bench, on which the young men used to sit.

We could get pickled onions from one shop and if you took your own jar the shopkeeper would take them out from a large jar with a special kind of scoop which would pick up quite a lot of onions. The price was twopence a scoop and one scoop was enough for about six people. You could also buy pickled cabbage like that and we could get hot faggots and peas with

gravy and had to take a basin for these. The shop cooked them about three times a week and we often had them for dinner; they were lovely, made with pigs' liver and onions. There was another shop where you could buy home-made cake - fruit, plain or seed, and if you could not afford the whole cake they would sell-it to you for a penny a slice, and quite a large slice at that. At the same shop we could buy broken-up biscuits and broken-up chocolate, all home-made; it was all quite good but had got broken up so they would sell it quite cheap. You could get a halfpenny-worth or a pennyworth and it was put into paper bags they made themselves, rolling the paper up in the shape of a cone, then twisting the bottom end.

We always had Cottage bread, which tasted much better. In those days bread was more like home-made bread, and better than the cotton wool taste we get today. There was a bakery not far from us and often I have taken a dough-cake Mother had made or a bread pudding and they would bake it. They would do this for anyone if it was taken in before nine in the morning and it could be fetched about three hours later for the price of one penny. People used to take more things in to bake in the summer-time as no one wanted to keep up the fire enough for baking at home then. We always had to take a cloth to fetch the cake or pudding home in case it was still hot. Of course we had to keep some sort of fire going at home winter and summer as we had nothing else to boil a kettle or to do any cooking.

Things by present prices seem very cheap - I remember that cigarettes cost fourpence for ten and some of the packets of cigarettes had cards in them with animals and butterflies and famous men and women on them. People used to save the cards and make up sets and I once saw a fire-screen a girl had made from cards with butterflies on them which she had collected. She pasted them on the front of the firescreen and it looked very pretty with all its different colours.

Chapter Three

Some Excursions and Some Escapades

Reg and I used to look forward to a Sunday School Outing. The children would scramble up on a hay cart and horse as we had to sit on the floor of the cart, packed in like sardines but we enjoyed it. We had to take our own drinking mug for our tea and we had the mug tied around our neck with a long piece of tape so that we could not lose it. I remember that on one of our "tea-outings" when Reg was about five and I was about nine, I had my orders to look after him but it turned out that he was looking after me most of the afternoon. As soon as we got into the field I slipped on some cow dung and began to cry. Reg tried to pull me up but as fast as he pulled me up I kept falling down again and you can imagine what I looked like. I left home with a lovely white lacy dress with a blue sash and by the time I had slipped-up a few times in the cow dung I looked a proper sight - and that was just the beginning of the afternoonl

One of the Sunday School teachers came to see what all the noise was about and when she looked at me she snatched me up and tried to get me in the tent but, as I was crying, Reg must have felt sorry for me for he told the teacher to leave me alone. She said "Go awayl" and with that he kicked her and said "Leave my sister alonel" and he would not leave my side as the teacher took off my dress and did her best to wash offi.the dung in a bowl. After that I had to sit in the tent until my dress dried and I missed all the races and all the fun..and so did Reg as he never left me. I did manage to get my dress back on before we had tea but it spoilt Reg's and my day. When we got back home Mum looked at me and said "What have you done to your dress?". Reg had to explain to her for I started to cry again. I was soon washed and changed and off to bed. I will never forget that outing.

In the summer school holidays Mum used to take us to the beach and usually another neighbour with her children would go with us. We used to take paste sandwiches and cold new potatoes, a piece of cake and lemonade. We thought that it was marvellous to be out on the beach,all day even though we had to walk there and back through Meyrick Park. I should think it was about three miles.

One summer day my Mum and Dad took Reg and me on a very special outing. Mum belonged to a Women's Guild and used to go to it every Wednesday afternoon; the women took their

knitting, sewing or darning and they had prayers and sang hymns. The mothers loved this as they didn't have much time to go out a great deal. On the day we went for the outing we rode in a chariot with four horses and there was a man who stood up at the back of the chariot blowing a very long trumpet We thought it was great fun and had a lovely day. There were quite a lot of our friends - mothers, fathers and children there - and we went to a big hotel room for tea. I had never seen the inside of a hotel before and I remember we had fancy cakes and strawberries and cream for tea. I think that Mum must have paid in for that outing at her Guild; anyway we enjoyed it, especially going out with Mum and Dad.

I remember when I was about eleven I overheard Mum tell my sister Beatie that she would have to look after us as there was a special play she and Dad wanted to see. It was summer-time and light evenings and, as the play was to start at six on that Saturday evening,they had to leave about four-thirty as they were going to walk all the way to Boscombe and it was a long walk. I went into our front room where I could see them leaving and, as soon as I thought they were gone round the corner, I dashed out of the front door to follow them. I kept a fair distance behind.them so that they would not see me and I remember I had no coat on but was wearing a white pinny. They were taking some short cuts across the common so I had to keep a good way behind them in case they spotted me.

I was getting tired of walking but was afraid to go back home in case my sister clouted me, which she did very often when Mum was out of sight, so I still followed them, having a bit of an idea that they were now not far from the Hippodrome where I had been once or twice with one of my sisters, I don't remember which one it was but she took Reggie and me to see a pantomime. I thought it better to let my parents see me now as I was so tired and hungry. I gave a little run to make a bit of noise as it was a rather quiet spot where they were but they still did not see me or hear me. I went a bit nearer and said "Mum!". They both turned round and I felt very frightened when Dad said "What do you think you are doing?" and I just said that I wanted to go with them. Dad said "You can't go there in a pinny" and they both stood there looking at me, and you can imagine how I felt. I suppose they felt sorry for me as Dad said "Are you hungry?" and when I said I was, he gave me a penny as there was a fish and chip shop near. He told me to buy myself some chips and then run all the way home but when I came out of the shop with my chips Mum and Dad were still there, so I offered them

a chip. Then Dad asked if Beatie knew I had followed them and when I said she didn't, he said "Right, we'd better take you back; she will be worried when she finds you missing".

I suppose they must have been tired too, for we took a tram home after Mum had taken my pinny off. I enjoyed the tram ride but I was still worried what they would do when we got home but all Mum said was "Upstairs to bed and don't you ever do such a wicked thing again!". Poor Mum and Dad - I often think about it now, to think they didn't see their show after all. I must have been a little terror of a child, the things I used to get up to.

When Reg and I were about eight and twelve years old we often went to Talbot Woods to pick up some pieces of branches which we used to pull from the trees when the wood was dry and we also brought home fir-cones for Mum's fire. One day Reg climbed up a tree and a branch snapped and, although Reg did not get hurt, it fell on to my foot which was very painful. I then did the wrong thing by taking off my shoe. We sat for a long while for the pain to go but it didn't get better and we thought we had better go home. When I went to put on my shoe I could not do so as my foot had swollen so much. Reg was quite worried but he said "Never mind, I will put your shoe in my pocket and will give you a piggy-back home". We tried that but I was too heavy for him so the only way I could manage was to lean on him all the way home, which was about a mile. We were both very tired and fed up by the time we got there but Mum didn't notice that anything was wrong for a while. Then she said "Where is the wood for the fire?". Of course, we had forgotten all about the wood which was still in the woods. Then she noticed that my shoe was off and my foot swollen. She put a cold water bandage on it but it did not do much good and I could not go to school for a few days as I still could not get my shoe on. Of course I should have had the Doctor to see it but we couldn't afford him. My foot took a long time to get well and, as a matter of fact, it never did get properly well as I still have a lump on the top of my foot and it still hurts if my shoelaces get a bit tight; I expect I broke a small bone in my foot. The next day Mum sent Reg back to the woods to see if the bags of wood were still there; they were and Reg managed to get them home somehow.

Now two stories about me and a halfpenny. First I remember when I was about ten my Mum told me that when I came in after school I would find a half-penny on the table with

a jug. "Go to the shop", she said, "and get a halfpenny worth of milk". You could get nearly half a pint of milk for that. Now at that particular time there was a new kind of sweet in the shop and I had been trying to get a halfpenny from Mum or Dad to buy some, but no one would give me a halfpenny. I wanted those sweets so much that I threw the jug on the floor and broke it and told Mum that I had fallen down and broken the jug and wasted the milk. We had no milk for tea that day but I had my sweets. It must have been a Wednesday as Mum was out when I got home from school; the key was under the outside door-mat and we all knew where to find it. Every time Mum went out she would ask a neighbour to keep an eye on us and Mum would do the same for her.

The other little story is this. When I got home from school one afternoon Mum was gone to her Guild meeting and I thought I was in the house alone. I saw a halfpenny on the mantelpiece and took it and went to the shop and bought some chocolate. On the way home I met Reggie coming from school and he asked what I was eating and I told him it was chocolate. He said "Where did you get the money?" and I said that I had picked it up, and gave him some of the chocolate. When we got home my sister Beatie was there - she had a whitlow on her finger and had been sent home from work as it was so painful. Of course, Reggie told her I had picked up a halfpenny and she looked straight at the mantelpiece and found the money was gone. She shouted at me and Reggie ran out of the house. When he had gone she got hold of me and gave me a good shake and pushed me in the front room where she sat me in a chair and dared me to move. She went into the living room and got some rope and tied me in the chair, saying that I could stay there until Mum came home. Then she told me what the halfpenny had been for - it was for me to buy some milk for tea. I started to scream and she smacked me, and at that moment Mum came home. Then, instead of telling me off Mum went for Beatie and told her to get out of the house. - "I will correct my children, not you", she said, and with that Beatie ran upstairs. Mum untied me and said that we had no milk for tea: after that I stayed very quiet for I knew that I had done a very naughty thing.

When it was time for dinner Mum sent me upstairs to tell Beatie to come down if she wanted any dinner, but she was not in her room. For a while no one worried about this as we thought that she had gone out of the front door to cool down, but when we had finished dinner and she still did not come in, everybody got worried and we all went out to look for her

but we could not find her. Dad went up to her room and found her tin trunk had gone and her clothes. Fred said that he would find her and he did - he went to my married sister,Mabel, and found her there. He said that she was to come home but she said that she was never going to go home again, so he picked up her trunk and took it back home and left her there. She came back the next day for Mum to do something about her finger. I think that I must have been about nine then and she was fifteen years older than me and she was always bossy with me. I always thought that she was jealous of me and when I got a bit older I found that this was so.

Those are my two 'halfpenny' stories - now two that I suppose you could say are about drinking. Mum used to make a lot of rhubarb wine and parsnip wine for the older ones of the family, of course. We did not have any until we were older so if the grown-ups had wine we had cocoa - we drank a lot of cocoa when we were children. I remember one day seeing all the bottles of wine lined up on the larder floor and I thought I would like to try some. There was no one in the room except me so I picked up a bottle to have a taste and, as I touched it, the cork blew out and hit the ceiling. It nearly frightened me to death and I never touched a bottle again!

On another occasion I remember it was Mum's birthday and Dad wanted her to go out for a glass of stout at the pub which he always went to. She said that she would rather have a glass of stout at home but he must have thought it was a change for her to go out so on this particular evening she did go with him. Well, Reg and I were supposed to stay indoors until they came back and one of my older brothers was in the house reading (I cannot remember which brother it was) and I expect that he was there to look after us. I must have been about eleven or twelve at the time and I whispered to Reg to go out with me. We sneaked off out of the back door without my brother noticing us go, he was too busy with his book. We knew the pub where our parents would be and when we got there Reg wanted to peep through the window to see if he could see Mum and Dad. I lifted him up to see through the window but he couldn't see much because it was stained glass of all colours but he said that he could see a man who lived in our road in there. We hung about outside the pub for what seemed ages. If Mum had known we were out there after dark she would have had a fit for she did not like children outside pubs.

Later on the man Reg had seen came out as the ‘Gents’ was outside in the yard and when we saw him coming out of the door we ran across the road and hid in a doorway but Reg was

determined to talk to him and when the man came back Reg ran over to him and said "Fight you for a halfpennyi". He replied "What are you doing out here by yourself?" and Reg said "My sister is over there", so I came over and he spoke a bit sharp to me and told me to take Reg home at once or he would tell my mother that we were out there. Reg said that we would go home if he would let him fight him for a penny. They had a little fighting match and, of course, he let Reg win and gave us both a penny and said "Go and buy some chips and then run off home". We were pleased about that and when we had eaten our chips we crept indoors and, to this day, I don't think our brother missed us as he was still reading his book. This was one episode Mum and Dad never found out about for, of course, when they game home we were playing about as good as gold. You know, I must have been a little terror when I was young - but never mind, Reg and I understood one another and we got on right well until he died.

Chapter Four

Brothers and Sisters and Working Days

My brothers, Walt and Fred, did the same kind of work as Father but they worked for a different boss as they did not believe in working on the same job as their father. My brother Will did not like work and he would not get a proper job but used to go to the golf course when he thought he would to carry the golf clubs for the better-off men. He got twopence a round and sometimes did only one round in a day. He then gave Mum one penny and, if he managed to do two rounds, he would give her twopence. He was rather lazy and would never stay in work for long and my other brothers were always on to him to get a decent job, and yet he was a very likeable lad. He didn't work properly until he got married and then he found that he had to work or go hungry! My next brother, Leonard was a good worker. He worked as an odd job man and would do anything gardening, getting land ready for the builders before they started to build their houses. and also carrying and fetching for the older men.

Walt, my eldest brother, was quite a worry to the family at one time because he had a very quick temper. Looking back, I wonder if he was ill or unhappy at the time because later on he was such a good husband and father. But as a young man he liked to have a drink with his friends and this sometimes led to trouble at home.

One Saturday night we had all gone to bed except Walt, who was still out. The next morning Mum got up first and when she opened the living room door there was a big dog tied on to the table leg and he growled and barked at her and nearly frightened her to death! As we didn't have a dog, she wondered how ever it had got there - then she remembered Walt was the last one to come home. Upstairs she went and told him to get up and let the dog out as it would not let her get into the room. Walt said he could not remember bringing home a dog and he didn't know who it belonged to and when he tried to get it out, you never heard such a noise! The dog was barking and Walt was shouting at it - then Dad had a go, but it took ages to get near it to untie the rope to let it out. The dog never came back so I suppose it found its way home.

Employment in Walt's sort of work wasn't too regular and there used to be times when he was out of work and it was soon after one of these spells that he decided to join the army.

He joined the Dorset Regiment and was sent with that Regiment to South Africa to fight in the Boer War. He came home on leave when the War was over and soon afterwards he got married. He seemed to have sorted himself out by then and Mother and Dad and all of us were pleased to see how well things worked out. His wife seemed to understand him and they raised a family of nine very happily.

My sister Beat left school at eleven years of age. Mum and Dad had had to pay a penny a week for her to go to school in her younger days and at that time children could leave school if they wished to go to work. Beat went into service and Mother had to make her some dresses and aprons for her first job. She was only eleven but in the mornings she had to be up at 6.30 to get the fires going (coal fires, of course) before breakfast. She would then have her breakfast in the kitchen with the other servants. Breakfast was porridge, bread and dripping and a mug of tea. Her wages were a shilling and sixpence a week and she had free food. She had one half-day off each week. It was very little, but for Mum there was one less mouth to feed.

Beat worked in service until she was about fifteen and then went to work as an ironer in Mr. Lander's laundry in Ridley Road. The laundry was in a building at the back of his house. At the time they still used flat irons which were heated on a round stove in the middle of the laundry where the irons were resting all the time so that they were always nice and hot. They did, however, need to be wiped with a cloth before starting ironing as they used to get rather dirty. Beat was earning by then about five shillings a week but she was very good and didn't keep much for herself, only about sixpence a week as she realised that it was a struggle.for Mother to manage. I was not born until Beat was fifteen but she told me all this when I was older.

Mabel was ten years older than me. She told me that she had to take me out in the pram when I was a baby and one day she wanted to play marbles with some other children. As she had me to look after she couldn't play, since every time she stopped the pram I started to cry. So she turned the pram to face the hedge so that I could not see her, but I made even more noise like that and this made her so cross with me that she decided to take me back home. On the way she had to go down a little slope and here she let go of the pram, and the pram and I went on without her. She told me that when the pram got to the fence it tipped up and I was

thrown out, but luckily I was not hurt. I bet she had a fright!

Mabel also went into service for a time after she left school, aged thirteen, but she did not settle as well as Beat and after a time she took a job as a nursemaid to three children but used to come home to sleep. She started at eight o'clock in the morning and worked until the children were in bed before she came home. She stayed in this job until she got married. I remember when she had her first baby I was eleven years old and I would go to her house as often as I could to hold the baby, and when it got a little older I pushed it out in its pram. I was so proud to be an Auntie! Around that age I was always taking the neighbours' children out, and even after I grew up you would very rarely see me unless I had someone's baby with me!

When I left school, at fourteen, my first job was in a laundry - the Castle Laundry in Castle Road. I was a calender maid and had to pull the sheets, towels, pillowcases and all the flat articles from the calender, which was a large roller affair. The clothes were put through it to save ironing them. Two girls stood one side to push the clothes through and two stood the other side to pull them through; then we had to fold them and put them through again to make them smooth. I was only working at that job for about a month, then I fainted one day and two girls had to take me home. Mother thought the heat of the laundry was the cause so she took me away from that job and I went as a daily maid, doing housework in the morning and taking out two children in the afternoon. I was earning 2/6d. a week and my lunch. It all helped Mother if we could have a job where we could have some meals out.

Reg was still at school then but when he left, at fourteen, he went to the same laundry as I had done, only he was driving a donkey and cart to take the laundry baskets with the washing back and forth. Through the years he worked in two different laundries. After the donkey he drove a horse and van; then the cars came, so he learnt to drive a car and van and he worked, up until he was six weeks off retirement, when he was taken ill and died of cancer. Of course he was married with a family then.

Chapter Five

War-time Days

When the First World War broke out I was about sixteen and most of the men and young lads were called up for military service. I saw an advertisement in the paper for women and girls wanted for milk rounds, so I applied and got a job. I had to drive a horse and milk float for Mr. Crooke, who had a dairy and shop at 535 Wimborne Road. In those days there were no milk bottles but a large milk churn stood inside the float with a tap which I had to turn on to fill up the milk bucket. Then I had to hang a half-pint or one pint dipper, whichever the customer wanted, from the bucket, carry the bucket and the measure into the house and fill up the customer's jugs. Sometimes if they had no jug the customers would bring a basin or a two-pound jam jar, or whatever they had, to put the milk in. . . .

I had a round of about three and a half miles to do each day and I liked the job, except when it was raining or snowing which was not so good. The wages were good for those days - 18/- per week and one pint of milk a day which, of course, my mother had as well as nearly all the money. I used to have about 2/- per week pocket money for myself and had to save out of that towards my clothes, but most of my clothes were what my sisters used to cast off and Mother would shorten them or do something with them to make them fit Of course, with the money we had for pocket money we could go to the pictures or the Hippodrome for 3d., or the better seats for 4d; we could buy a pennyworth of sweets or chocolates to eat in the pictures and a pennyworth of chips when we came out - and we still had a penny left out of sixpence if we went in the cheap seats!

I had been on the milk round about eighteen months when I saw an advertisement for girls to work in a wash-bottle shop yard, so I applied for the job as it was 2/- more per week. My mother said I would be better off staying on the milk round as I would not gain much as we would lose our pint of milk a day but I felt I wanted a change. However, I found out it was very hard work and the smell of the beer was not very nice for the job was at The Bournemouth Brewery in Holdenhurst Road. The Off-licence shop was in the main road but at the back was a yard made of bricks and concrete - very cold. There were six girls in the wash-bottle department and we stood all day long washing beer bottles. There was

a sort of long brush sticking out from an engine affair which was going round and round all the time. What we had to do is hard to explain but I will try. Well, as I said, the brush was going round and it never stopped for us to put the brush into the bottle - we had to be quick enough to hold the top of the bottle away from us, and slip it on to the brush and we had to hold it firmly or it would fly off the brush. It was very difficult at first but I got used to it in time. After the bottles were washed we had to put them on a rack and they would move along to a girl at the end for rinsing and then move on to another girl who dried and labelled them. I don't quite know how it worked; it must have been run by a motor of some sort but I wasn't very interested as I was too busy. We all wore coarse aprons and clogs as the floors were always wet.

I remember one day I had to take two wire baskets full of empty bottles, about six in each basket, down some stone steps and my foot slipped and I fell from about halfway down the steps to the bottom. You can imagine what a noise that made as the bottles crashed to pieces and there was me lying in water at the bottom! A man who was working down there picked me up, and when he stood me on my feet he was surprised I was not out to pieces. I was quite all right but I got a telling off from the manager who said I was supposed to make two journeys with the baskets so I could hold the rail as I walked down, so after that when I was sent down I just carried one. We were all allowed half a pint of beer or stout with our sandwiches in our lunch break from one until two o'clock but I didn't like the taste of that so I had lemonade. It was fun really; the girls all liked their job and we were quite happy.

Food and drink were very scarce during the First World War. We were not rationed with books like we were in the Second World War but had to fight our way through the shops to get food. When I was about seventeen one of our neighbours came running in to Mother to tell her they had some potatoes and butter in a shop. There was a long queue when I got there but I remember getting 1 lb. of potatoes, 4ozs. of butter (which was very salty), and about 2 ozs. of cheese. As I was coming from this shop I saw a queue outside another shop so I joined it and managed to get a pound jar of mixed fruit jam. Mother was so pleased with what I got that she let me have the first slice of bread and jaml

The bread we had was called Standard Bread and the young folk made up a song about it. It went something

like this - -

On Standard Bread they feed me,
On Standard Bread they lead me,
On Standard Bread, bring out your dead,
On good old Standard Bread.

It didn't taste too bad but the colour was not good - it was grey looking. My brother will said it was made with half flour and half potato peelings. Although the food was scarce we did manage to get something to eat every day. I remember for quite a few months there were no potatoes at all but plenty of butter beans, so we had those instead of potatoes.

When my brother Fred came home on a fortnight's leave from the army - I was about sixteen then - he brought me a present. It was like a brooch but had no pin and when I asked him what it was, he said "I don't know. I made it myself in the trenches". Then he said "Perhaps you can get a pin put on from the jeweller's?" So I did just that and I remember it cost me ninepence. I asked him how he made it and what was it made of and he told me it was made from a piece of German shell. He cut it to shape with a penknife and polished it with the point of a darning needle and when I asked him how long it took to make he said he had no idea as he could only do it when the Germans stopped firing for ten minutes or so. When he told me all that I was so proud of him, to think he did that for a young sister. I still have the brooch - I could never part with that. I also remember he sent both Mother and myself, through the post, a postcard with a little pocket on it in which there was a handkerchief. The cards had been censored before we got them; I still have mine around somewhere.

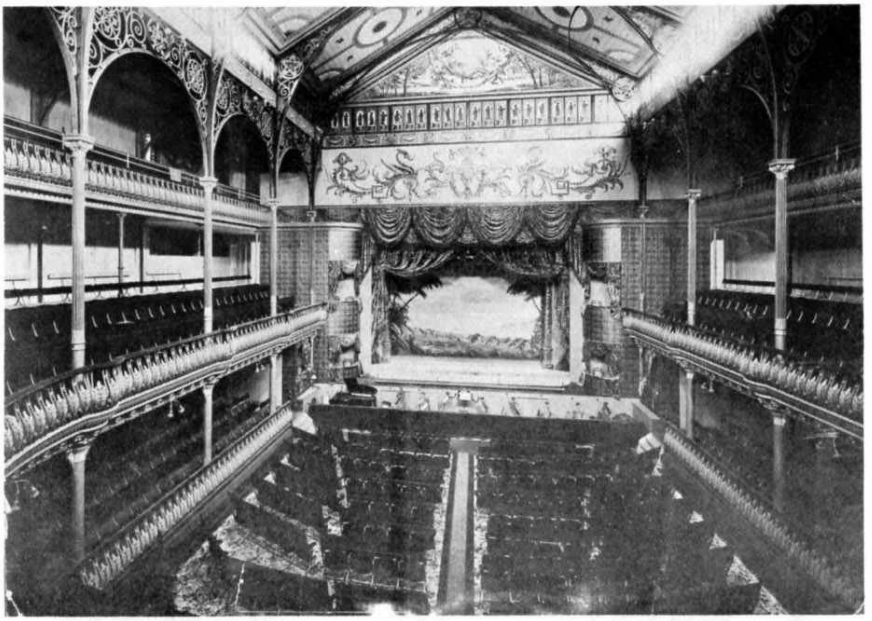
When I was eighteen I got home from work one day to find my mother sitting in the living room with my sister and a neighbour; ‘they were all crying. Mother had just received a telegram to say my brother, Leonard, had been killed in Turkey. He was twenty-one. She never got over the shock and after that we often used to find her crying while she was trying to carry on with her work and cooking. Then when I was nineteen she had to be put to bed and she didn't get up again, but was bed-ridden for five and a half years. As I was the last girl not married, it was my duty to give up my work to take care of her. I did my best for her, and my younger brother, Reg, and my father, as all the rest of my brothers and sisters were busy with their own families. Reg got married at nineteen and that just left me with Dad.



Arthur Hoare in 1912



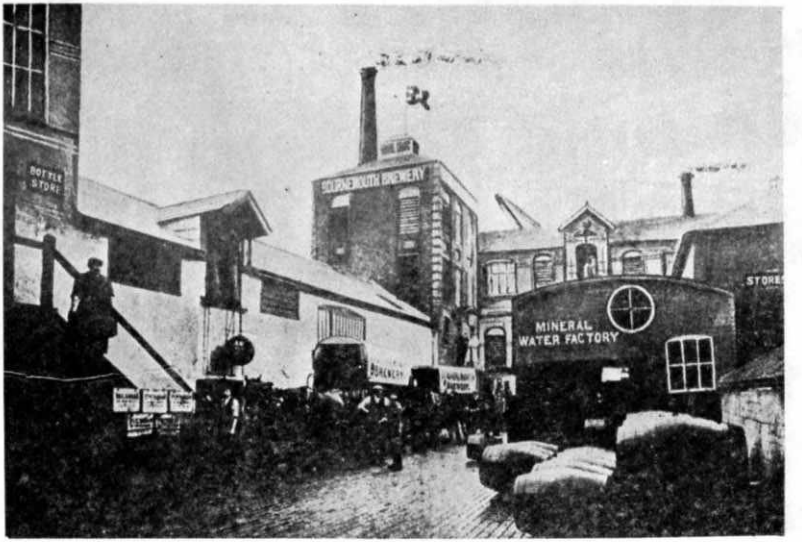
Nellie in 1914



Boscombe Hippodrome Interior c. 1908



Corn Merchant's Shop and Carts, Peter's Hill



Bournemouth Brewery in Holdenhurst Road

My brother, Leonard H.J.Barter, has his name, with those of other Winton chaps killed in the First world War, on the war memorial just inside St. John's Church door, on the right as you go in.

The Doctor said we would have to get Mother moved downstairs as it was getting too much for me running up and down stairs so many times a day, I did not get any rest. So my two brothers, Fred and Will, carried her downstairs and put her a bed near the window in the nice sunny front room. She would lie there, looking out of the window,and she used to wave to the people passing by and would watch the gate to see if any of the family was making a visit.

During the first year of Mum's illness I had an offer to look after a little girl about fourteen months old, her name was Tessie. I said I could look after her at home so they brought her cot in and I cared for her. She was a lovely child. Her mother was Irish and unmarried, but a very nice person. She gave me 7/6d. per week and of course we had to feed Tessie out of that, but we managed. The mother found her clothes and she sometimes brought Mum a small drop of brandy, and fruit and flowers. It was nice for Mum to see the little one pottering around and sitting on her bed, and Dad loved her. He would take her for little rides in her pushchair and let her walk if she wanted to.

I will tell you what happened to little Tessie. Her mother took her away from us just as we had got used to her as she wanted to go back to Ireland to live with her parents. Her father was ill and her mother wanted her to go home and get a job in Ireland. Well, Tessie's mother did not want to leave the child too far away from her so she took her to Ireland and put her in a convent home so that she could see her sometimes. Of course her parents did not know she had a child - she said she would not be allowed home if they found out. We were very upset when we found out what she wanted to do. I wanted to keep Tessie as we had got so fond of her and we even offered to keep her for no payment as we would all help to clothe and feed her - my brothers and sisters were quite willing to help - but it was no use, she wanted to take her. We would not have minded so much if she had taken Tessie to her parents - but to put her in a convent, we all thought that was awful! I have often wondered what happened to the child.

By this time Dad had given up work as he was often not well and, to help out, we were allowed a five shilling grocery ticket each week. It does not sound much today but in those

days the groceries were much cheaper. I will tell you some of the prices as I remember them. Tea was 3½d. or 4d for a quarter of a pound; Mother always insisted on having the best as she liked a good cup of tea. It was called Lipton's Red Label and was 4d. a quarter. Cheese was about 4d. a pound; butter 5d. and 6d. a pound - we never had margarine in the house as Mother didn't believe in it and Dad used to call it 'cart grease'. Sugar was 2½d a pound. I have a little cookery book that may give you more of an idea of the prices. The book is priced at one penny and was given me about fifty years ago. I will write out one or two recipes, they all had prices (shown here in brackets)

Herrings Stuffed **(Average cost - 6d)**

A fresh herrings
2 tablespoons breadcrumbs
1 tablespoon milk
½ tablespoon chopped suet
1 tablespoon chopped parsley
¼ teaspoon mixed herbs
Salt and pepper

Irish Stew **(Average cost - 8½d)**

1 lb. Scrag end mutton
2 lbs. Potatoes
3 medium sized onions
½ pint water
Salt and pepper

Rabbit Stew **(Average cost - 1/-)**

1 Rabbit 1 tablespoon flour
A slices bacon
1 onion
1 pint water
Salt and pepper

Steak Pudding **(Average cost - 10d)**

1 - 1 lb. pieces of steak
½ lb flour
4ozs. suet
½ teaspoon baking powder
1 gill cold water
Salt and pepper

Queen Cakes **(Average cost - 1d each)**

6 ozs. flour
3 ozs. butter
3 ozs. sugar
l oz. currants
½ teaspoon baking powder
Few drops of flavouring
Pinch of salt
2 eggs

Victoria Sandwich **(Average cost - 6d)**

2 eggs	1 teaspoon baking powder
Their weight in flour	1 tablespoon milk
and sugar	Jam

Home-made Lemonade **(Average-cost - 1½d)**

1 lemon 1 pint boiling water
1 oz. sugar

These recipes will show you what the price of food was in those days.

The last year of my mother's life I had to have a bed-chair to rest on at night by the side of her bed but I could not sleep as she used to cough a lot and she had pains in her left arm about every two hours. I had to keep pieces of flannel around the fire all the while to dab on her arm to ease the pain. The flannel had to be very hot otherwise she could not feel it and said it was no good. It was impossible for me to sleep and the Doctor gave me some medicine to keep me going. For the last six months I had to get either a brother or sister to come and sit with me at night and all that time I did not go to bed but just dozed in a chair for fear Mother would die while I was asleep. Four days before my twenty-fourth birthday she died quite peacefully while my aunt was sitting with her as I was cooking something for my Dad's tea. By the time I got from the kitchen, Mother had gone; I was so shocked, yet relieved to know her suffering was over.

The undertaker wanted Mother to be buried on the same day as my birthday but Reg would not hear of that so she was buried the day before. After all that, when my birthday came I knew nothing about it as I slept all day because the Doctor gave me a sleeping draught. When I woke up. Mabel and Reg were in my room with some presents for me - if I remember rightly I think it was a box of chocolates and some fruit. Mum was sixty-five when she died, at that time she had twenty-one grandchildren but there have been a few more since then. After her death I just had my Dad to care for - he was lost without Mum, but no trouble at all.

When I felt better I got a job, doing housework in the morning and taking care of two children in the afternoon. I was pleased to earn a little money for myself as all the time I could not go out to work I had no money at all, just my food

and clothes. My father would give me a few coppers if I asked him but I very rarely did. Now, in November 1980, I have just been thinking how different things are. They tell me home-helps are paid £1.60 per hour; when I used to go to work I got ten pence an hour in the old money, that would be four pence now, and we had to work very hard for our little money as there were no hoovers or carpet sweepers. I used to have to brush and scrub, and sometimes polish, the floors, and spring cleaning was very hard work. I remember, too, the gas stoves were black outside so they had to be black-leaded, then rubbed with a cloth until you could nearly see your face in them; also there was a kitchen range to polish every morning. I walked to work each day, it took me half an hour each way, from Winton to Queen's Park Gardens across the golf course, in rain, snow and sunshine. Never mind the weather, we did it! People don't walk far these days, what with their cars, motor-bikes, etc.! .

Chapter Six

Courtship and Marriage

About two months after Mum died, Beat and her husband, Reg and his wife and my brother Will were going on an afternoon and evening trip out by coach. My brothers belonged to a Club and every summer they would get up an outing for themselves and their wives so Reg asked if I could go as I hadn't been anywhere for so many years and the Manager said I could. When Reg asked me if I would go I refused at first and said that it wasn't right to go for an outing so soon after losing Mum as we were still in our black clothes. Of course in those days you were in mourning for twelve months after you lost a near relation, but in the end they talked me into going with them.

We started off at about 2.30 p.m. and the coach was full About 4.30 p.m. we stopped to have some tea and I was sitting on the inside seat near the window and my brother will was sitting next to me. He said he was getting out but I said I would stay in my seat until they came back as one or two more women were not getting out. As soon as Will had gone, a young fellow sat down next to me - he had come from the back seat. I said to him "What do you think you are doing? ' That's my brother's seat", but he just winked at me and then got up and said "Coming in for a cup of tea?" but I replied "Of course not". When my brother came back I told him what had happened and he said "Why didn't you go and have some tea with him? He's a very nice chap".

When everyone had returned to their seats, this same chap looked at me again and winked and I noticed he was very handsome with lovely blue eyes - so it was love at first sight on a coach! When we arrived at our destination he was one of the first to get out and he waited for me and helped me out, then whispered "Would you have a drink with me?". I told him I didn't drink but he said "What about a lemonade?" so I gave in and went in the little inn with him. We all sat around one big table, my brothers and sisters and me and this fellow; having a drink and a chat. I had my lemonade, all the others had beer or stout. When it was nearly time to leave my brother Will said "You two can sit together going home as I'm going to sit on the back seat with some of the lads". So that's what happened he went to the back seat and the young man sat with me.

Well, after that we saw one another nearly every evening

for about four and a half years and we wanted to get married but it was rather difficult. I still had my Dad to look after and Arthur (that was his name) was living at his sister's house as she had a lot of trouble about that time. Her husband went off with another woman and left her with two young children so Arthur more or less had to stay there to help her out with money. When I told Mabel we wanted to get married, she said she would have Dad to live with her and look after him, so we were able to go ahead with our plans.

Money was scarce in those days so we had a quiet wedding at the Bournemouth Registry Office and my brother Reg and his wife were the only ones with us. Arthur had a new navy suit, made to measure, which was a surprise to me, with a nice white shirt and tie and new shoes. I had a new navy costume and white silk blouse. My sister Mabel bought my hat as a wedding present, it was a cream-coloured straw with a cream ribbon bow, very smart.

As soon as the wedding was over, Reg and Glad went home. In those days we could not afford to go away, so we had the day to ourselves and we got on the first tram that came along which was going to Poole. It was an open-top tram and we went upstairs and soon there was a shower of rain but we didn't bother about that. When we got to Poole we went into a Cafe and had a nice meal, then, after we'd walked around for a while, we decided we would go to Swanage by train. Arrived there, we found a nice little inn and went in for a drink and snack of food and then we explored Swanage and during this walk we had another shower of rain. Of course I had my straw hat on and no umbrella and, all unknown to me, my hat went to seed - it went into a point at the top. I must have looked a sight walking around like that but I didn't find out until we got back to our rooms that night. As we went in at the front door, just inside the hall was a large mirror and I had a look in and saw my hat. I looked a proper sight! I said to Arthur "Why didn't you tell me my hat had gone to seed?" but he said he hadn't even noticed that it had. I don't know how long it had been like that - it could have happened on top of the tram. Of course I could not wear it any more but we all had a good laugh about it afterwards. It was a good thing I didn't have my photograph takenl

After we were married I used to go and see Dad nearly every day and my husband used to go and see his sister nearly every day, until her children got older and she went out to work. It was while Dad was living with Mabel that a very

sad accident happened. Opposite the house in Portland Road was a sand-pit and one day a neighbour's two small children, a boy and a girl, were playing there; Dad happened to look out of the window just as an avalanche of sand fell on the children. The boy was trapped up to his waist but the little girl was completely buried. Dad dashed across the road and dug frantically at the sand with his hands and got the girl out but he was too late to save her. She was dead and he could only lay her body on the grass while he rescued the boy. It must have been a terrible experience for him.

Mabel looked after Dad until he died, he was seventy-two then. He died suddenly from a heart attack which was a shock for us all but more so for my nephew, Bert, who was only fourteen. He went to Dad's room with a cup of tea for him and found him dead in his chair; Bert never forgot it. By the time my Dad died I had two children - a boy, Maurice, and a girl, Marjorie. My husband and I both lost our Dads within five months.

After Arthur and I were married we went to live in Portland Road for a short time and then moved to Cove Road. Arthur had gone to India during the First World War; of course I didn't meet him until after the War but he told me about it. He said he was very ill out there with a disease called Cholera. All the men in his platoon caught it and he and one officer were the only two who pulled through. He said when his officer found out that they were the only two who survived out of the platoon, he patted him on the back and said "well done". Arthur was a cook in the army and when he was discharged he had a certificate for being a good cook. I found that out after we were married as he could cook better than I could!

He was also very clever at woodwork and he made a lovely sideboard and tried to keep that a secret from me. I used to see him coming home from work, pushing his bike and whistling away quite happily. When I looked out of the window I often saw him with some wood tied to his bike but when I asked him what he was going to make with it, he said "Oh, just some little thing I'm going to knock up". Well, as he spent so much time down at the bottom of the garden, shut in the shed, I wanted to find out what he was making as I could hear him sawing and hammering. So one evening I took him down a cup of tea, thinking I was going to see what he was doing, but he must have spotted me coming because he rushed outside and locked the shed door. He had even put up a curtain so

that I shouldn't see what he was doing! When I asked him again what he was making, he told me to wait and see and took his tea and sat outside and drank it and he wouldn't go back inside until I left him. Nearly every day, after he had gone to work, I tried to see through the window but I couldn't see a thing as he always had the key.

This went on for several weeks and then, one day, my brother Will came in to see us. Before he left, my husband said to him "Come down the garden and see the chickens". Well I didn't take any notice of that as everyone who called had to go and see his chickens but a little while after I heard such a commotion outside the back door and one of them pushed the door open and they came in with this lovely sideboard. I never saw anything so lovely, for hand-made. It had two glass sliding doors fixed at the top for fancy china, and beading around the doors and drawers; and it was highly polished. I don't know how he could have made such a beautiful piece of furniture, shut up in a shed to do it.

Another time he made a wardrobe, and a little bed for Maurice as when we had our second baby we needed the cot for her. Then he made a child's dresser and shelves for Reg's little girl and bought her a tea-set to put on it; he also made a little potty-chair for Marjorie when she was about six months old. Before that Arthur had made Maurice a little wheelbarrow which the child wanted to push everywhere he went, he even had to have it by the side of his bed at night in case he lost it. Well, one day Maurice did lose it. He went out to play with some more children and when he came in he didn't have the wheelbarrow. I asked him where it was and he said he couldn't find it. I went to all our neighbours to see if their children had seen it but they all said they hadn't and we never saw it again. I had a nice time, I might tell you, with Maurice after that as he was lost without his wheelbarrow. But his Dad made him a stool so he forgot about his loss after a while.

Before I had Marjorie I said to my husband that if I had a sewing machine I could make the children's clothes to save a bit of money and a few weeks later he came home with one that he had bought off one of his workmates for £3, which was a bargain as it was in proper working order. After that I made their clothes and some of my own - every minute I could spare, I was sewing; I never wasted a moment. Both my husband and myself always seemed to be working in those days but we were very happy and never quarrelled over anything.

My husband's birthday and mine were on the same day and when Maurice was very small I remember telling him that Daddy and I were going to have a birthday the next day. Just after I had told him this he asked if he could have sixpence out of his money box and when I asked him what he wanted it for, he just said he wanted to buy something. I guessed what he wanted it for and when he and the baby and I went out shopping that morning, he said "I want to go in the sweet shop, but you mustn't come in", so he went in on his own and when he came out I couldn't see what he had as he had it in his pocket. The next morning he ran into the bedroom, where he had hidden his secret, and went to his Daddy first and said "Happy birthday, Daddy" and gave him a packet of five Woodbines, which cost 2d. at that time. Then he came to me and said "Happy birthday, Mummy" and gave me a bar of chocolate, which also cost 2d., then I heard him put the change back in his money-box. He was a very shy and quiet boy but he had his head screwed on all right as he could not have been any more than three and a half.

Not many months later, when Marjorie was about ten months old, I took her to a Baby Show. The Doctor there had just started looking at my baby when the Nurse called me and said I was to go home as they had taken my husband there as he had collapsed at work: I wrapped the baby in a shawl and put her in the pram; Maurice was with me so I had to put him on the pram as well as he wasn't yet four years old. I ran nearly all the way home and when I got there my husband's boss was with him and another workman. They were trying to wash him before the Doctor arrived. By the time he came Arthur was rolling about the bed with pain in his chest. The Doctor gave him a sleeping draught and said that when he woke up all I had to give him was milk until he called again the next day. When the Doctor came again he told me that Arthur had gastric ulcers, but he got a little better and got up again and within a week was back at work. After that, though, he was often very sick and could only eat milk puddings and custards. I begged him to stay at home but he would go to work. He used to take a milk pudding in a dish and warm it up for his lunch. He was a painter and decorator by trade and he loved his work. About that time he was working quite near to the house of his boss who used to let him go in there to have his lunch and the boss's wife warmed up the pudding: I didn't know what to give him for dinner for a change as the Doctor said he only had to have a milk diet. About a month later, Arthur was too ill to go to work and the Doctor said he would have to go

into hospital for an operation, only before they could operate I had to give him only one cup of milk and water every two hours for six weeks. You can imagine what he was like, living on milk and water only for six weeks - he was so thin and looked so ill. The awful thing was he was taken to the hospital one Thursday morning and the following Thursday he died. He had an operation for the ulcers and they also took his appendix out. It was such a shock for me when he died as we were so happy together and he loved his children.

Chapter Seven

Bringing up a family

After my husband died I did not realise at first how we were going to manage, as I could not go out to work with the two babies - Marjorie was thirteen months old and Maurice was only about four. Then, just after the funeral, my husband's boss came to see me to ask if I had put in for a Widow's Pension. I had not - I didn't even think I had to have a pension. I was in such a state of shock that I had not thought about it, but then I knew I had to buck up and try for a pension and look after our children. If it had not been for them, and knowing I had to care for them, I would have gone to pieces. I did get a pension, though it was very small in those days. I had 10/- a week for myself, 5/- for Maurice and 3/- for Marjorie - eighteen shillings to keep three of us. When I think of the struggle I had, I wonder how we ever managed to live, but we did. I cannot ever remember when I had no food for the kids or myself, and they were always clean and tidy as I was still making their clothes. After Arthur died I could not settle anywhere for long and we had about seventeen moves - to flats, rooms and even a caravan - before I finally settled in Sedgley Road, where I lived for eighteen years.

I remember when Marjorie was fifteen months old and was crawling about, her Uncle Reg came in one day and said "Can't she walk yet?". I said she couldn't and he then said "I bet I can make her walk", so he took two pennies out of his pocket and stood her up against the wall, with her back to the wall. He then held out a penny in each hand to her and said "Come on, get the money" and she came about two steps before she sat down. He picked her up and again told her to come and get the money and as she took a few more steps he walked backwards a little each time she moved, so in the end she walked the length of the room. Reg said "Just like a woman, they will do anything for money!" and he gave her the pennies and got her money-box and told her to put them in the box and she did - and from that day she could walk by herself. Reg was always a good lad and everybody loved him.

On another occasion, when Marjorie was about two and a half years old, my niece Dorothy came in one Saturday to see if I would let her take her out in the pushchair. I said I would get her ready and when she was ready to go, Dorothy said to me "Aren't Marjorie's shoes too heavy for her?". I replied that she seemed to get around all right

in them, and I told Dorothy that I had to buy the stronger shoes to make them last - another thing, the heavy ones were cheaper than the lighter ones. Dorothy didn't say any more about it, but when she brought Marjorie home she had bought her a pair of black patent shoes with little buckles on them, much lighter. When Dorothy put them on Marjorie's feet, I shall never forget how the child danced around the room in them - she was so excited to have shoes with buckles.

When the children were very young I could not go out to work as I would not leave them with anyone but when they were both at school I got a morning job as I would not let them come home from school to find I was not there. People did not leave their children when they were young to come home and find no one in the house, not until they were older did we leave them. No one will ever know what a struggle I had to bring up those two children on my own and money so scarce. Never mind, I managed to pull through and I am glad I did as they turned out so well.

I have told you about Christmas when I was a child, how Reg and I made paper chains and decorated the room with them and with holly and mistletoe and how pretty it looked, though we never had a Christmas tree. When my own children, Maurice and Marjorie, were about eight and five years old, they used to make paper chains too, but I did usually get them a Christmas tree. Trees cost about a shilling each then but if you left it until Christmas Eve you could usually get one cheaper, for about ninepence, we did not have lights on the tree, only some cotton wool threaded through with some cotton or string to make it look like snow. Then I used to drape it around the tree and hang up a few sweets and some small toys for the children. They did have a little more than I had when I was a child because I always used to pay 3d. or 6d., whatever I could afford each week, into a Christmas Club at a shop to help me get them a few extra things for Christmas, but they did have fun with the few things they got.

I remember one day when Maurice was about ten, he asked me if I had some old-curtains and when I asked him what he needed them for, he said he wanted to put some curtains in Marjorie's doll's house. I said she hadn't got a doll's house but he replied "Yes, she has because I have just made her one". I remember I was doing the washing at the time in the kitchen while they were playing in the sitting room, so of course I had to go and see this doll's house.

Well, he'd found a shoe box and had cut some holes in the lid to look like windows and stuck it somehow on the box. It did look something like a little house and he had a little piece of felt for a carpet and some little pieces of wood and cotton reels for chairs. I found him an old piece of net curtain and he cut it to fit with an old pair of scissors, and when he'd finished, he hung the curtains with some drawing pins. Then he made Marjorie some rag dolls, and she also had a little woolly doll which she called 'Trouble' because he would not sit up properly. Every time she sat him up he would fall over, so I suppose that is why she gave him the name because it was giving her a lot of trouble to try to make him sit up!

Well, at last the house and the dolls were finished and Maurice sat the dolls on their little seats and Marjorie was so pleased with it. She played for hours with the doll's house and dolls her ‘big brother‘ had made for her, and Maurice was quite pleased himself when he saw her playing with them.

I think I must say something about the Second World War. We were rationed for food and clothes then and everybody had a ration book. I think it was better in some ways as we all had a chance to have some food without having to queue for it. Of course it was not much. I do remember we had one egg per person each week (we had ours for Sunday), 2 ozs. of tea each, half a pound of sugar, 2 ozs. of butter and about one rasher each per week. The sugar was enough as I didn't have sugar in my tea, and neither did Maurice, but I cannot remember if Marjorie did. I know I used to let a friend of mine have a cup of sugar every week and sometimes I would get an extra bit of tea. Jam was on points and I think meat has, too. Clothes were a worry for a lot of people as they never seemed to have enough coupons for what they wanted, but we managed as we couldn't afford many new clothes.

When the Second World War broke out Maurice was about nine years old and Marjorie about six. Maurice belonged to the Lifeboys and one day he came home from the meeting and said the head one wanted all the boys to go camping. I asked him if he wanted to go and he said 'Yes' - I wanted him to say 'No' as I didn't like the thought of him going away from me, as he had never been away from home before and as the War had just started we didn't know what was going to happen. However, he wanted to go so I went to see the man in charge and he said to let him go as he would be quite all right as they had two men and two-women-in charge. So I let Maurice go and I was glad I did as he did enjoy himself, and he talked about

it for days when he came home. When he was ready to set off I gave him a shilling for pocket money - I could not afford any more - and what do you think he did? From his shilling he brought Marjorie and me home a present of a bar of chocolate each. It was a bit soft by the time he got home with it, but I thought it was a kind thought.

Later on,when she was old enough, Marjorie joined the Girl Guides and I remember one year, when she was camping at Dudsbury, she wanted me to go on the Wednesday afternoon as that was the day they could invite their mothers to tea. I took a friend with me and when we arrived we saw all the girls running around, but we couldn't see Marjorie. When we'd finished tramping around in the mud someone gave us an orange box to sit on and I asked one of the girls where Marjorie was. She said it was her day to fetch the bucket of milk from the other field and eventually Marjorie and another girl arrived with an empty bucket. I asked her where the milk was and she said "It's still in the cow". It seems they went before the cow had been milked! I had never seen Marjorie so filthy - she was covered in mud and straw and her face was really dirty. When I said "Haven't you had a wash today?" she replied "We'll all have a good wash before we come home!"

When tea was ready we were still sitting on our box. I was given a very strong cup of tea in an enamel cup, a slice of cake which looked as though it had been on the ground, and a slice of bread and jam, and as we were about to eat, a lot of wasps started buzzing around us! We didn't enjoy the tea much but we had to get on with it as the girls were all sitting around watching the mothers, and some fathers, having their tea and of course we had to say it was very nice. We have often had a laugh over that outing but I am sure they all enjoyed themselves.

Marjorie went on from the Guides to the Sea Rangers until she was about seventeen or eighteen. She was very good and the head one would have liked her to have gone on to be the Captain of the Guides but where we were living then we didn't have a spare room where she could study and there would have been a lot of book work. It was a shame really as she would have been quite good at that, as she was interested in the Guide work.

Maurice left school at fourteen and as soon as he left my pension was cut down to 15/-, that was 10/- for me and 5/- for Marjorie. Just before this, when Marjorie was about ten, I had had to sell my sewing machine to buy the children

some shoes. I was sorry to have to let it go but I remember I got £8 for it as at that time sewing machines were scarce. I used to earn a few coppers doing a little sewing for the neighbours so I did miss it, and of course I'd made all Marjorie's clothes, though I do remember she once said she wished she could have a dress bought from a shop instead of home-made. Somehow I managed to buy her a dress but she had to keep it for best, she wasn't allowed to wear it to school, only to Sunday School.

When Maurice earned his first week's wages, he came home with a little parcel. I asked him what he had and he said it was something he had always wanted. It was a jar of Brylcreem for his hair. When I told him he was not supposed to spend his money as soon as he got it but must bring it home first so I could see what he earned, he said I could have what was left and he gave me 2/6d. I gave him back sixpence from the half-crown as I could not let him go without any pocket money, but I said "Another time, bring your money home before you spend any". He was very good after that; he would bring his money home and then we would sort out how much I had to have and how much he could keep. .

Marjorie left school when she was fourteen and then I had no pension for the children, only 10/- a week for myself, but money was a little better, as she earned about 19/- a week. Both children were very good with their money, and I could manage pretty well then, with them working and my own part- time job.

EPILOGUE

When the children got married and left home and I was left on my own, I went out quite a lot for rides on buses to see different places and the shops that I never got round to doing as the money would not stretch to bus rides. Marjorie got married first and now she has three girls, Susan, Wendy and Dena, and a stepson, Nicholas. Then Maurice got married and he has one girl, Gillian, and two boys, Philip and Robert. Gillian is now married and she has a daughter, Julie, and a son, Andrew, so I have seven grandchildren and two great-grandchildren, and I love them all.

In August, 1973, after living in Sedgley Road for eighteen years, I moved to a flatlet in Turbary Park Avenue. I am quite happy here with my own little flatlet and a Day Centre next door and a Warden if I am taken ill, with a bell for her over my bed. I also have a telephone in my room and a colour television, and the neighbours are very kind. All my family live quite near and come to see me - my daughter comes every week to bring me some shopping and do most of my laundry - and I go to the Day Centre twice a week and meet some very nice people around my own age, and I am glad to say I am not lonely, although I live alone. I think I am very lucky to have my family not far away as some elderly people have no one to turn to and I have heard some very sad stories from some of the old folk at the Centre. I have been thinking about this, and have come to the conclusion that I must have done all my crying when I was young, because I never cry now.

I think if, when you are getting older, you can keep warm and have good food and a nice cup of tea, and the television and radio, you don't hurt. I have had some very worrying times in my life but I have had some good times, too. I have lived through two wars, and lost a brother in the First World War, so I don't think I have done so bad. Now I have my memories and I have one very good friend living in the same house as I do and we often have a little chat, so I am quite happy the way things have worked out for me, thank God.

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